

Aquila chrysaetos

Golden eagle



Location North America, Europe, Asia, N. Africa

Length 30–35 in (75–90 cm)

Weight 6½–14 lb (3–6.5 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

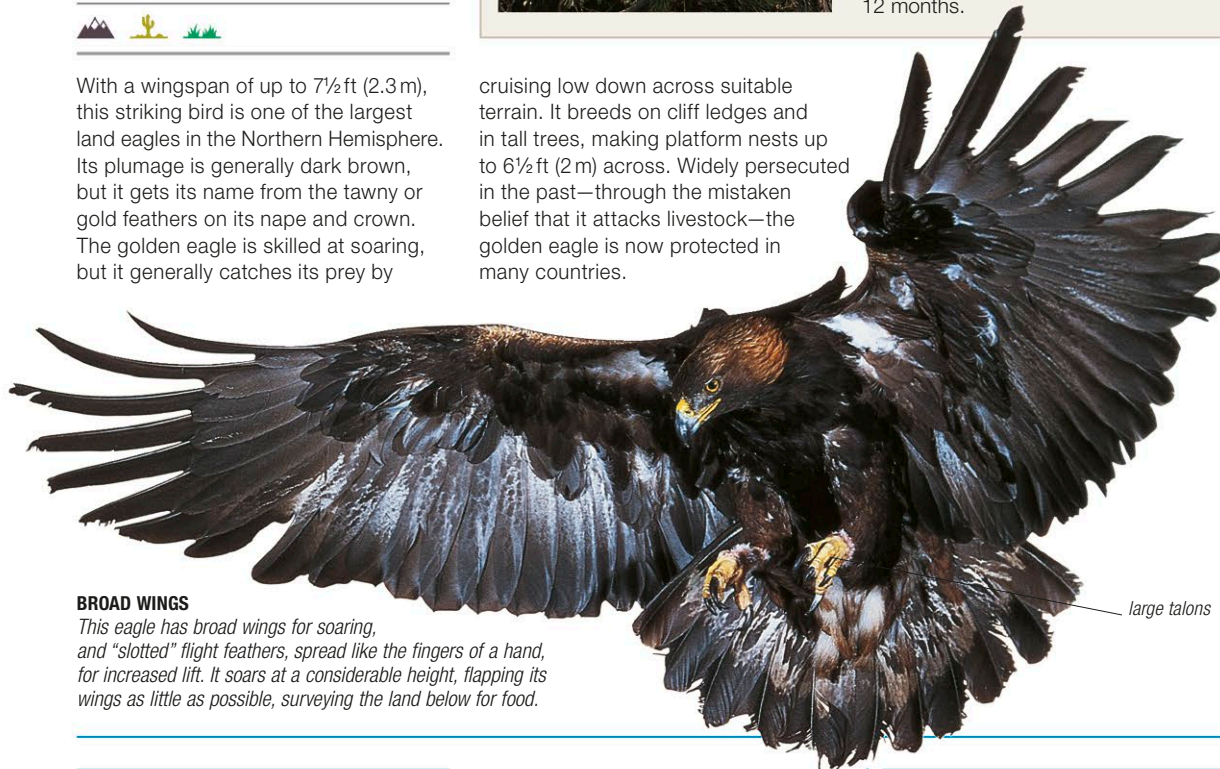
Migration Partial migrant

Status Least concern



With a wingspan of up to 7½ ft (2.3 m), this striking bird is one of the largest land eagles in the Northern Hemisphere. Its plumage is generally dark brown, but it gets its name from the tawny or gold feathers on its nape and crown. The golden eagle is skilled at soaring, but it generally catches its prey by

cruising low down across suitable terrain. It breeds on cliff ledges and in tall trees, making platform nests up to 6½ ft (2 m) across. Widely persecuted in the past—through the mistaken belief that it attacks livestock—the golden eagle is now protected in many countries.

**BROAD WINGS**

This eagle has broad wings for soaring, and “slotted” flight feathers, spread like the fingers of a hand, for increased lift. It soars at a considerable height, flapping its wings as little as possible, surveying the land below for food.

FEEDING THE YOUNG

This eagle has a wide-ranging diet, including carrion and living prey, such as rabbits, squirrels, and grouse, and even tortoises in the southern parts of its range. Parents feed their chicks, by tearing food up into strips, for several months after they have fledged. Young birds take 4–5 years to mature, but mortality is high, especially in the first 12 months.

*Pithecophaga jefferyi*

Philippine eagle



Location Philippines

Length 34–39 in (86–100 cm)

Weight 10–18 lb (4.5–8 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Critically endangered



Threatened by forest clearance and by hunting, this gigantic eagle is one of the world's rarest birds of prey. It feeds on a wide variety of animals, including monkeys, snatching them in a low-level attack. Attempts are being made to breed the eagle in captivity, but with a rapidly shrinking habitat, its future looks uncertain.

*Aquila audax*

Wedge-tailed eagle



Location S. New Guinea, Australia (including Tasmania)

Length 32–39 in (81–100 cm)

Weight 4½–12 lb (2–5.5 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Least concern



This eagle is Australia's largest bird of prey, with dark brown plumage, and a long, graduated tail that gives it a distinctive silhouette in flight. It feeds

on a wide range of animals, including other birds and rabbits, and it also eats carrion, taking the place of vultures in a continent that has no vultures of its own. Wedge-tailed eagles usually nest in trees, lining their nests with leaves.

*Harpia harpyja*

Harpy eagle



Location S. Mexico to C. South America

Length 35–39 in (89–100 cm)

Weight 8¾–20 lb (4–9 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

Migration Nonmigrant

Status Near threatened

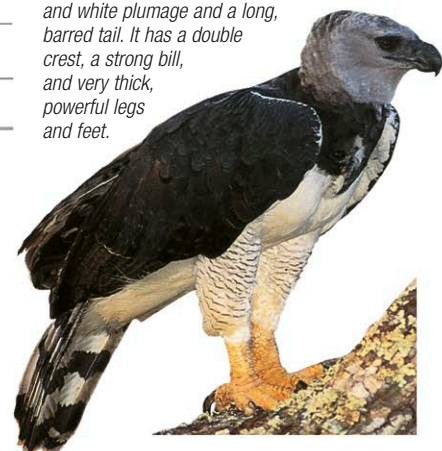


In habitat and lifestyle, this immense bird closely matches the Philippine eagle (see above), although it lives in a quite different part of the world. Despite its great size, it is unusually agile, which enables it to steer through the treetops to catch its prey. Sloths make up about a third of its food by weight, but it also eats a wide range of other animals, including snakes, lizards, and

macaws. Harpy eagles make stick nests high up in old trees, and they often perch on exposed branches, watching the forest canopy below for signs of prey.

POWERFUL PREDATOR

The harpy eagle has gray, black, and white plumage and a long, barred tail. It has a double crest, a strong bill, and very thick, powerful legs and feet.

*Polemaetus bellicosus*

Martial eagle



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 31–34 in (78–86 cm)

Weight 6½–13 lb (3–6 kg)

Plumage Sexes alike

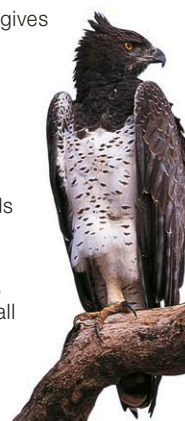
Migration Nonmigrant

Status Vulnerable



This is the largest of the African eagles, and one of the biggest eagles in the world. It can be found in a wide variety of open habitats, from semidesert and

steppes to foothills, and also in moderately forested areas. Its prominent brow gives it a menacing expression. The abdomen is white with gray to black speckling. The martial eagle soars for extended periods in good weather, searching for prey such as gamebirds, hares, hyraxes, small antelopes, monitor lizards, and other medium-sized vertebrates.



CONSERVATION

The population of the harpy eagle is declining as a result of habitat destruction. It needs a very large area to hunt, which makes it vulnerable when a continuous stretch of forest is divided into isolated tracts. Young birds are now being radio-tracked via satellite, to determine their range and the space they need to survive.

